

Braves' King was here for Lemon's feat

Once upon a time a six-foot, six-inch Virginian named Jim Lemon hit four home runs in one game at Rickwood and Atlanta Braves caravanning manager Clyde King was recalling it here Wednesday.

King saw the historic feat, though his memory of it is about 80 per cent, overall, trustworthy. Fiction is now stamped with fact in King's recount, but no harm done. King's story is more dramatic. Don't change it.

What did he remember most about Rickwood, the post-war Mobile Bear righthander and later Cracker pilot was asked?



VAN HOOSE

"First thing is Eddie Glennon pacing that roof, hollering at umpires, and next Jim Lemon hitting four home runs that night, and the fifth time lining one off the rightfield wall about two feet from the top. That'd been something, wouldn't it, five in one game?"

It certainly would have been—but four was pretty hot. Dern hot.

But Lemon didn't come close to five. Hundreds of games since have dulled King's recall of that July, 1955 drama. Same as mine, for I was there, and can't focus on a single Lemon home run though I vividly remember that crowd.

This was Birmingham's first all-star hosting. Attendance was 19,830—only 244 short of Rickwood's all-time audience for Dizzy Dean vs. Ray Caldwell.

There were walls of people inside the playing field, eight or ten deep within 20 feet of the homeplate ump. Foul balls killed no one. That's the most memorable non-feat for me.

—Ermer winning skipper

Reason I know King's story was not quite right is because I checked News microfilms. I was writing the paper's Page-1 Vulcan column that year and was strictly a spectator that night. Zipp Newman, Walton Lowry, Benny Marshall, Grant Rice, II, and Ronald Weathers handled the game.

Uncharacteristically, Marshall punned a lead, calling it a 'Lemon of a game'. Atlanta baseball writer Bob Christian penned that the All-Stars won, 10-5, "with Lemon-aid". Grand old Henry Vance, P.A. announcer, deadpanned after Lemon's fourth roundtripper: "As Mr. Pillsbury would say, that takes the cake." ... As you might judge, it WAS a warm evening.

Lowry wrote the mainstory, detailing Lemon's show evening—Lemon being a Chattanooga outfielder, headed for Washington-Minnesota stardom, tied at the time with Nashville's Bob Hazle for league homer leadership with 18.

First inning, ex-Tide end Ed White of Memphis (and Anniston) and Memphis' Luis Aparicio on base, Lemon home run to left, Lefty Jim Kite pitching...

Third inning, White again aboard, Lemon home run to left, John Gabler pitching...

Fourth inning, Lemon lineout to shortstop Jerry Lumpe, Dave Benedick pitching...

Seventh inning, Lemon home run into grandstand-bleacher gap in right, Jack McMahan pitching...

Ninth inning, Lemon home run, deep into leftfield bleachers, Lefty Jim O'Reilly pitching...

Winning manager, Cal Ermer, Chattanooga, said after the game he thought Lemon had a chance to be a major leaguer. Little Rock writer Orville Henry voted Benedick most-valuable Baron. He got Lemon out.

—Losing streak

Old newspapers fascinate me and after finishing note-taking about that all-star game I kept checking the next few days.

In our relaxed chat Wednesday, I gathered that King was an Ermer all-star coach in 1955. He wasn't. But in a few days he was named Atlanta manager, succeeding fired George McQuinn.

This didn't surface during the rapping with King but I'd bet he'd recall his first week as Cracker field boss. He was 0-7 after it.

He won't remember what Atlanta drew, in dear old Poncey, that seventh straight L-Day but he can look it up: 960.

The same night in Birmingham, Phil Page Barons against Andy Cohen last-place New Orleans Pels, Rickwood had 3,762.

This was 20 years ago, come July, when Birmingham was something special in baseball. You've heard it before, and it's true: one never can tell.

Atlanta may draw a million in 1975. It almost did in '74. Rickwood will probably be dark.